

Troubleshooting Methodology

Use this when: a ticket lands and you want a repeatable path from "it's broken" to fixed, verified and documented.

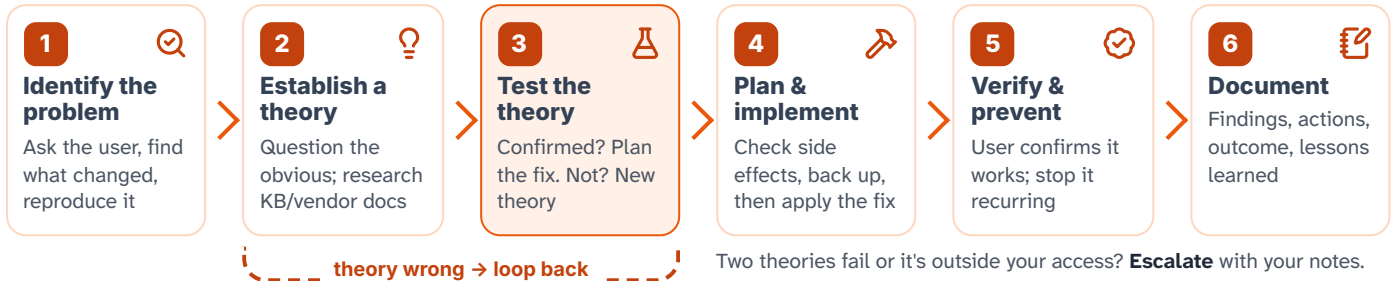
CompTIA A+ V15 · Network+ N10-009
Sheet v1.0 · Sep 2026



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The 6 steps (CompTIA A+)

Network+ uses 7: step 4 is split into "plan" and "implement or escalate"



Step 1: ask the user

- 🕒 When did it start? Did it ever work?
- 🔄 What changed: update, new device, moved desk?
- 📄 Exact error text or a screenshot?
- 👤 Just you, or others too? Other devices?
- 🔁 Can you show me the steps?

Step 2: question the obvious

- ☐ Power, cable, Wi-Fi on?
- ☐ Restarted (really)?
- ☐ Updates pending?
- ☐ Caps Lock / keyboard layout?
- ☐ Right account / tenant?
- ☐ Disk or mailbox full?
- ☐ Date & time correct?
- ☐ Service outage page?

Ways to find the cause

Bottom-up	OSI L1 → L7: cable, link, IP, app
Top-down	Start at the app when the network looks fine
Divide & conquer	Start in the middle: ping the gateway
Compare	Diff against a working device or user
One change	Change one thing, test, then the next

⚠ CAUTION Back up user data before reimaging, resetting profiles or replacing disks.

Escalate with

- ☐ Impact: who, how many
- ☐ What you tried + result
- ☐ Priority / SLA clock
- ☐ Steps to reproduce
- ☐ Logs, screenshots
- ☐ Best contact time

Talk to the user

- ✓ Say what you'll do next and when you'll update them
- ✓ Skip jargon; repeat the issue back in their words
- ✓ Never blame the user; thank them for the details

Step 6: ticket note template

Symptom: Outlook won't connect, 3 users, since 09:10

Cause: expired password on shared mailbox

Fix: reset via admin portal, re-signed in

Verified: user sent test mail 09:42

Prevent: added expiry alert

⚠ DANGER Suspect malware or a breach? Stop. Disconnect from the network, don't wipe, escalate to security. Verify identity before any password reset.

Set priority

example: follow your SLA

	URGENCY HIGH	MEDIUM	LOW
IMPACT HIGH	P1	P2	P3
MEDIUM	P2	P3	P4
LOW	P3	P4	P4

REMEMBER ⚠ Can't reproduce it? You can't prove it's fixed
Escalate early, with what you tried and the evidence

- Tell the user what you're doing and an ETA
- Close the ticket only after the user confirms